

USA & CANADA TO COTONOU THE CAR SHIPPER'S PLAYBOOK 2026

From the auction lot to the streets of Cotonou - every step, every cost

Thousands of diaspora members and dealers ship cars from US and Canadian auctions (Copart, IAAI, Impact) to Cotonou every year. Most learn the hidden costs the hard way. This playbook maps the complete journey with professional cost simulations - so your landed-cost spreadsheet is right BEFORE you bid.

1. The full cost stack (what your spreadsheet must include)

Cost block	Typical range / rule
Auction price + buyer fees	your bid + \$300-800 fees
Inland tow to port (US/Canada)	\$150-600 by distance
Ocean freight (RoRo / container share)	\$900-1,800 to Cotonou
BESC/CTN (mandatory tracking note)	per shipment - never skip
Benin customs duty	see formulas below
Port & clearing fees (Cotonou)	~550,000 F all-in with broker
Registration, plates, inspection	~40,000 F + insurance

2. Benin duty in 30 seconds (2026 schedule)

Customs values your car with its own reference table (not your invoice), adds 600,000 F flat freight for North America, then applies:

Category	Formula
Sedan under 13 HP fiscal	CIF x 31.60% + 98,600 F
SUV / 13 HP and above	CIF x 40.21% + 98,600 F

Simulation examples for popular auction picks: Camry 2007 -> 926,426 F (\$1,654). Highlander 2008 -> 1,895,964 F (\$3,386). RAV4 2013 -> 2,410,275 F (\$4,304). Corolla 2014 -> 1,365,993 F (\$2,439).

Selling to Niger instead? The re-export flat fee is 305,000 F - many dealers land cars in Cotonou precisely for that corridor.

3. The playbook, step by step

1

Pick the right car

Check the 13 HP threshold BEFORE bidding: a V6 pays ~22% more duty. Salvage titles are accepted but document everything.

2

Book the shipping

RoRo is simplest for runners; container (shared 40ft, 3-4 cars) for non-runners/high value. Ask for Cotonou, Benin - not Lome - if your clearing is here.

3

BESC/CTN immediately

Your forwarder or we open the Electronic Cargo Tracking Note at booking. Mandatory, fined if late.

4

Send documents early

Original BL (or telex release), bill of sale, title. Courier originals to your broker BEFORE the vessel arrives.

5

We clear at Cotonou

Declaration, duty payment, port fees, release - allow 3-5 working days with complete documents.

6

Registration or re-export

Benin plates for local use, or corridor convoy to Niger/Burkina with the 305,000 F flat fee.

7

Money transfer tip

Duties are paid in FCFA. Budget the FX: \$1 = ~560 F; card and mobile-money payments accepted through our online tools.

4. The 5 mistakes that cost shippers real money

- **Mistake 1:** Bidding on a V6 'bargain' - the 13 HP surcharge eats the discount.
- **Mistake 2:** Late BESC - automatic fine at destination.
- **Mistake 3:** Originals arriving after the vessel - storage fees start immediately.
- **Mistake 4:** Assuming Lome/Tema costs apply in Cotonou - each port has its own fee stack.
- **Mistake 5:** No clearing budget - use our simulator BEFORE bidding: adtranslogistics.com/simulateur.

English-speaking team, door-to-door service, references available. AD TRANS LOGISTICS - Licensed customs broker, Port of Cotonou - WhatsApp +229 01 97 50 05 55 - www.adtranslogistics.com